sealed, too sacred to be accessible to the uninitiated. This same tradition was followed by the early Jains and the early Buddhists. But everything changed with the establishment of what fully deserves to be called the first Indian empire by Chandragupta, founder of the Maurya dynasty.

Prior to his abdication, Chandragupta's long-time teacher and counsellor had been a Brahmin named Chanakya, also known as Kautilya, who has been called 'the Indian Machiavelli', although it really ought to be the other way round, with Chanakya by far the more astute of the two, and, of course, earlier by some fifteen hundred years. This is because Chanakya was the author of a famous treatise on political economy and statesmanship entitled *Arthashastra*. It was known about but thought to be lost to history until 1891 when the Maharaja of Mysore set up the Mysore Oriental Library as a repository for the growing collection of ancient manuscripts gathered by Benjamin Rice and his colleagues. Shortly after its opening a Brahmin from Tanjore appeared with a tattered manuscript which the librarian, Shama Shastry, recognised as a medieval copy of Chanakya's legendary lost masterpiece and subsequently (in 1909) published in English to widespread acclaim.

Chanakya drew on his own first-hand experience of politics and statesmanship as a chief minister at the very heart of Chandragupta's growing empire. He also appears to have served Chandragupta's son and successor Bindusara, who was a more orthodox supporter of Brahminism than his father and extended his empire with further conquests in the west and east. How far south this conquest extended is unknown, although the *Arthashastra* describes the Dakshina as abounding in 'conch-shells, diamonds, precious stones of other kinds, pearls and articles of gold', and the Dakshinapatha or 'road into the Deccan' as being 'frequented by many and easy to travel by'. So clearly there was some interaction at that time between the Mauryan empire north of the Narmada and the country beyond. This